THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Prelim

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise. The last room trains your ears.

THE ROOMS

1 · Practising well
2 · Loud and soft
3 · The staff and the keyboard
4 · Reading the notes
5 · How long is a note?
6 · Time signatures
7 · Repeats
8 · Touch: smooth and short
9 · Major scales
10 · Minor scales
11 · Chords and triads
12 · Ear training

Practising well

SCAN TO LISTEN

1 **Slow**

2 **Small**

3 **Correct**

Good practice is **slow**, **small** and **correct**.

Slow enough to get it right. A small piece at a time. And right from the very first try.

AT THE PIANO

Choose two bars of your piece. Play them at half speed, with no wrong notes.



When it is right **three times** in a row, go **one step faster**.

If it falls apart, step back down. This is the metronome ladder.

AT THE PIANO

Set a metronome (a ticking beat-keeper; there is one in the app) to 60. Play your two bars three times. All right? Move up to 66.



Every piece has a **hardest bar**. Find it and practise it **first**, while your mind is fresh.

Then join it to the bar before and the bar after.

AT THE PIANO

Find the hardest bar in your piece. Play it slowly five times, then play it with its neighbours.

1 Good habit?

★☆☆

Circle helps or wastes time. The first is done.

the hardest bar first	(helps) · wastes time
always from the top	helps · wastes time
play faster after a slip	helps · wastes time
three correct, then faster	helps · wastes time
hands separately first	helps · wastes time

2 My fifteen minutes

★★☆

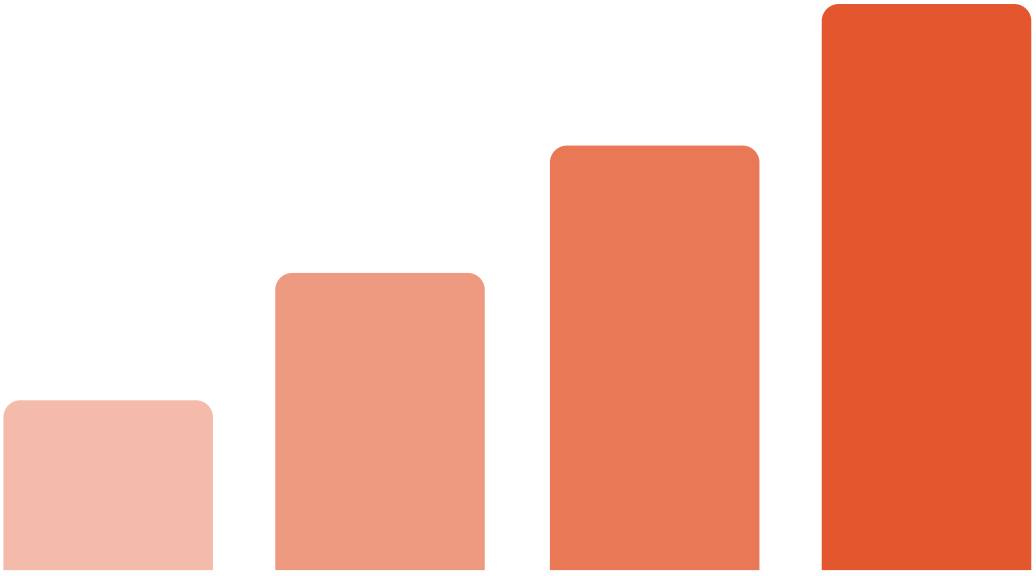
Plan your practice: what will you do in each part?

TIME	WHAT
2 min · warm up	
5 min · hardest bars	
5 min · join them	
3 min · play it through	

Room 2 ◆ 1 of 3

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



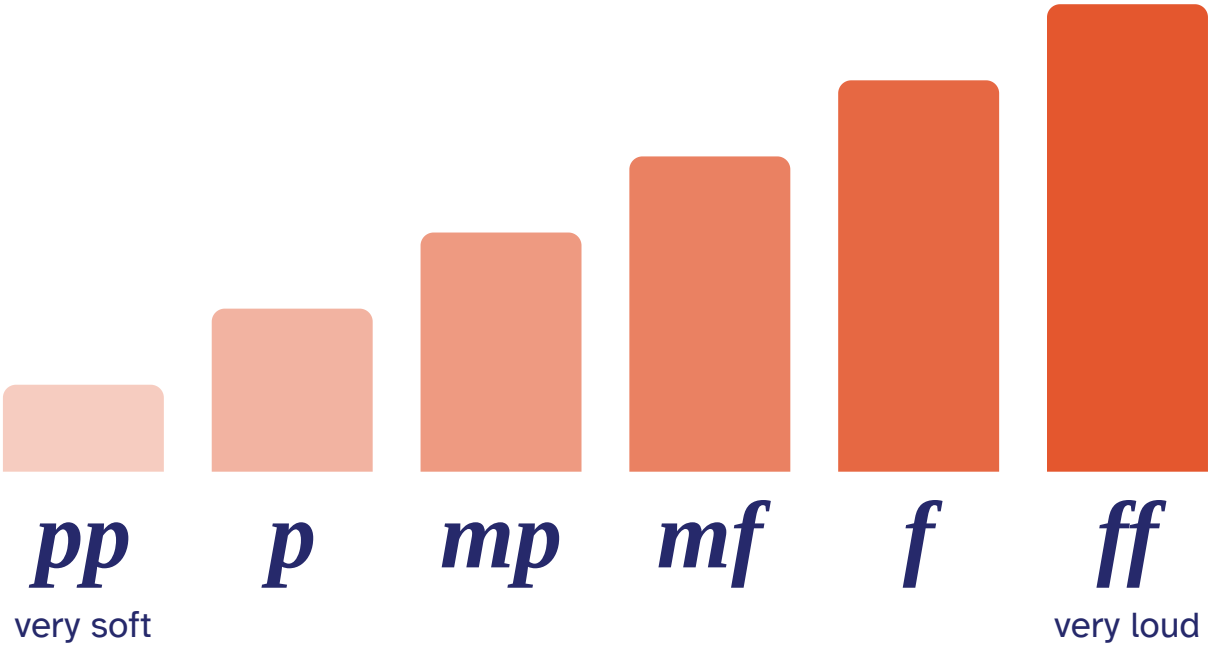
p	*mp*	*mf*	*f*
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud

Four signs tell you how loud to play. ***p*** is *piano*, soft. ***f*** is *forte*, loud.

Mezzo means medium: ***mp***, mezzo piano, is quite soft and ***mf***, mezzo forte, is quite loud.

AT THE PIANO

Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed.



Two letters mean **very**: ***pp*** is very soft, ***ff*** is very loud.

That makes six steps, from a whisper to a shout.

AT THE PIANO

Play C six times, one step louder each time. Then come back down the steps.



crescendo

getting louder



diminuendo

getting softer

A sign that **opens** means get louder little by little: **crescendo**. A sign that **closes** means get softer: **diminuendo**.

The wide end is the loud end.

AT THE PIANO

Play C D E F G getting louder, then G F E D C getting softer.

1 What does it mean?

★☆☆

Write the meaning. The first is done.

SIGN	MEANS
mp	quite soft
mf	
pp	
ff	

2 Softest to loudest

★★☆

Write the six signs in order, from the softest to the loudest. The first is done.

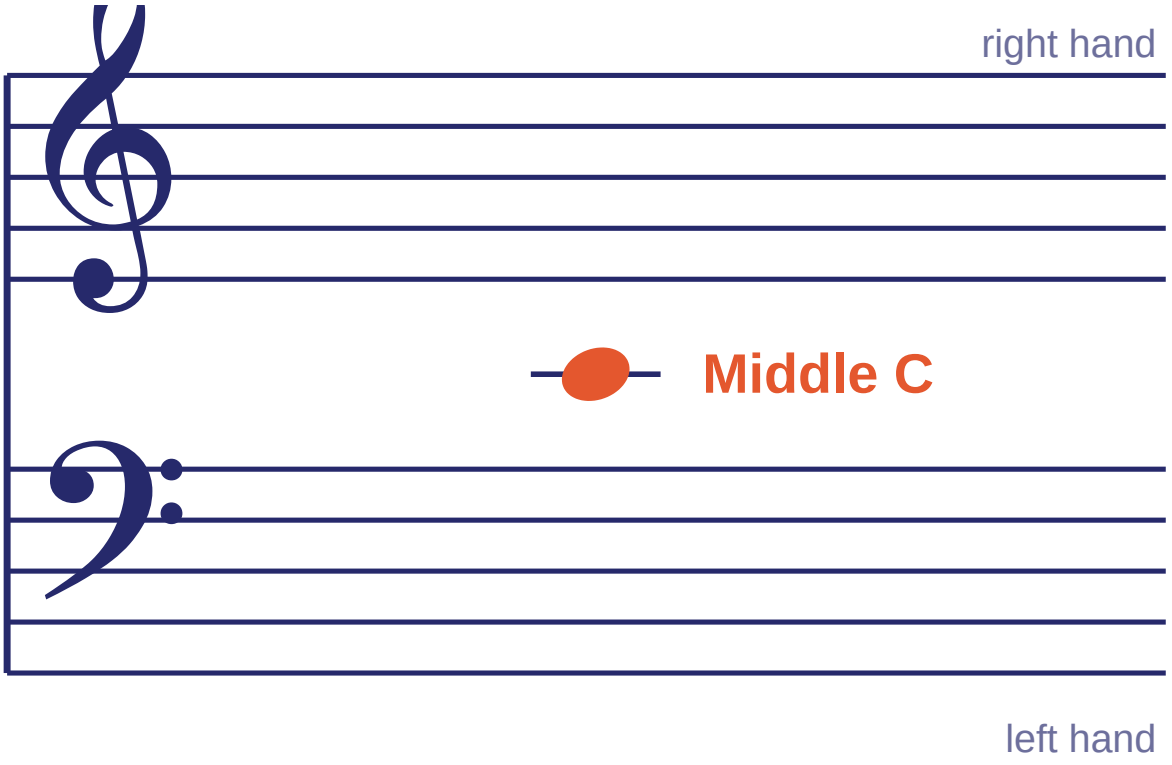
pp ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

f · mp · ff · p · mf

Room 3 ◆ 1 of 2

The staff and the keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN



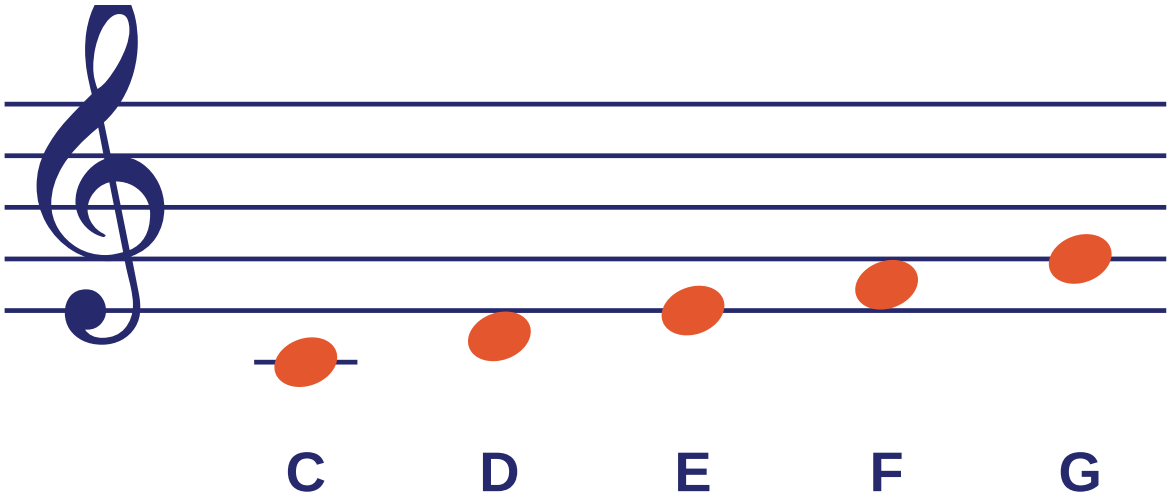
Piano music uses **two staves** joined together: the top one for the right hand, the bottom one for the left.

The curly sign at the top is the **treble clef**. The one below is the **bass clef**.

Middle C sits between them, on a little line of its own.

AT THE PIANO

Find Middle C: the C nearest the middle of your piano. Play it with each thumb.



From Middle C, each **step up** on the staff, line to space, space to line, is the **next white key** to the right.

Line, space, line, space, line: C, D, E, F, G.

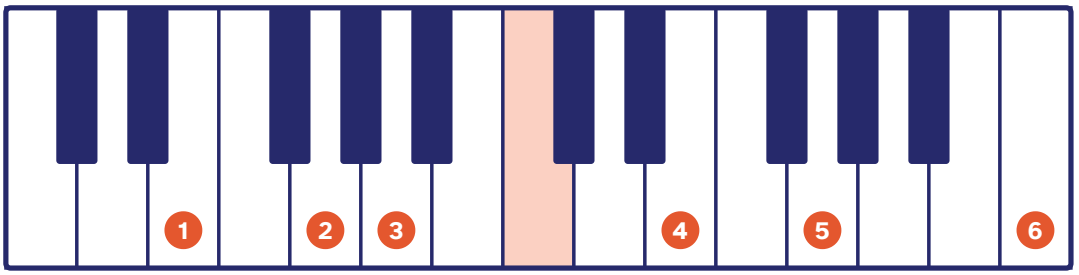
AT THE PIANO

Right thumb on Middle C. Play C D E F G while you look at the five notes on the staff.

1 Which key?

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Middle C is marked. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



Middle C

1 E 2 ____ 3 ____ 4 ____ 5 ____ 6 ____

2 Count from Middle C

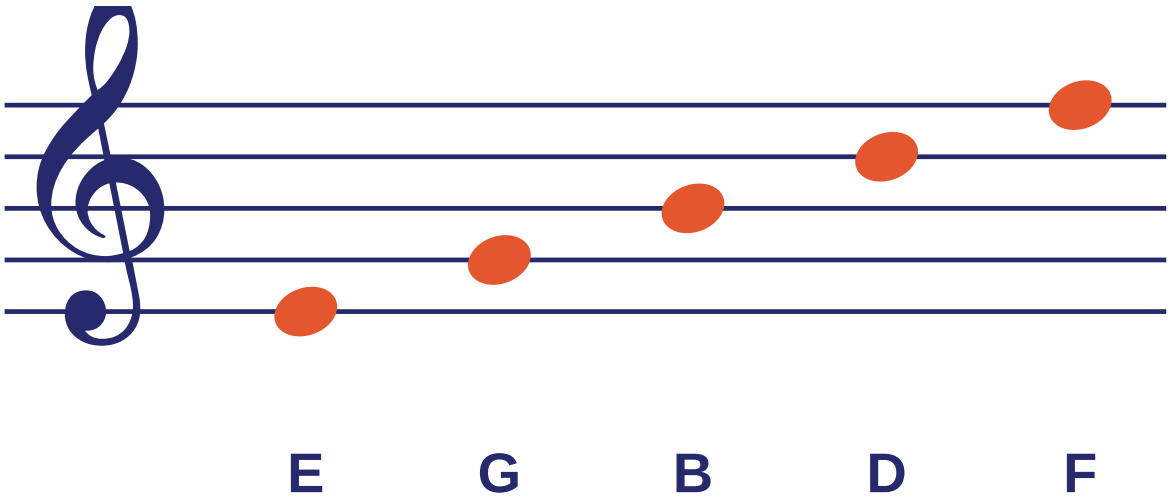
★☆☆

Count the notes, both ends included. The first is done.

FROM	TO	NOTES
Middle C	up to treble G	5
Middle C	down to bass F	
Middle C	up to A	
Middle C	down to E	
G	up to the next G	

Reading the notes

SCAN TO LISTEN

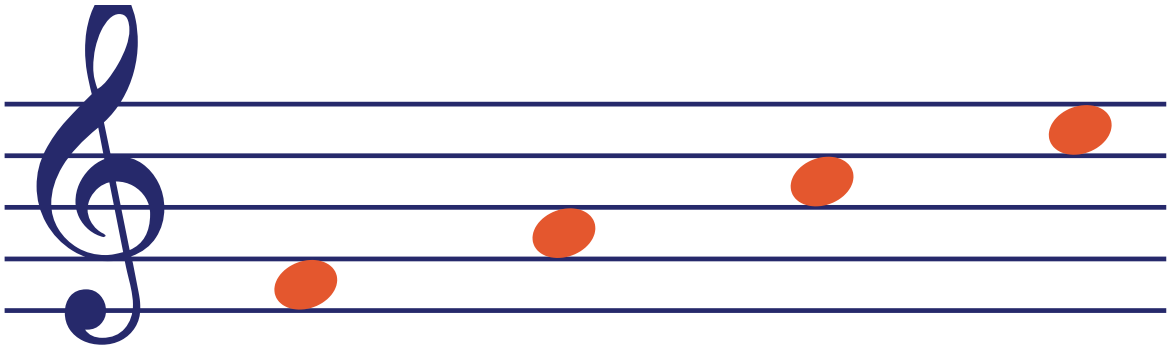


The five **lines** of the treble staff are **E G B D F**, from the bottom up.

A sentence helps: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**eserves **F**un.

AT THE PIANO

Play E G B D F going up from the E above Middle C, saying the sentence.



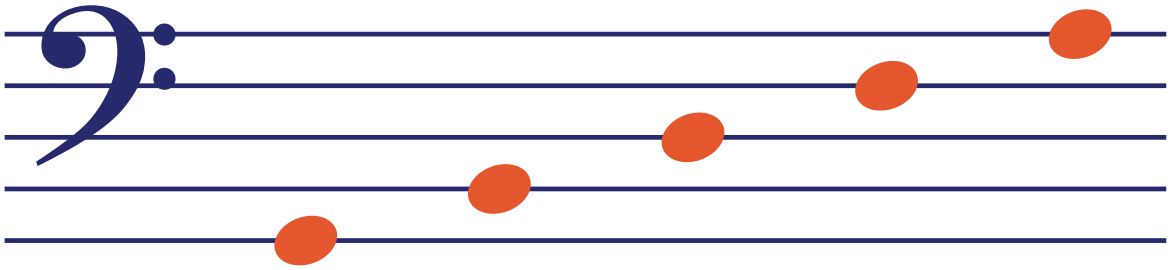
F A C E

The four **spaces** of the treble staff spell a word: **F A C E**.

Lines and spaces take turns, so the notes go F, G, A, B, C, D, E.

AT THE PIANO

Play F A C E going up. Then play F G A and say which is a space and which is a line.



G B D F A

The bass staff is different. Its **lines** are **G B D F A**: **G**reat **B**ig **D**ragons **F**ly **A**way.

Its spaces are **A C E G**: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

AT THE PIANO

With your left hand, play G B D F A going up from the second G below Middle C, saying the sentence.

1 The letters on the staff

★☆☆

Write the letters from the bottom up. The first row is done.

Treble lines	E	G	B	D	F	
Treble spaces						
Bass lines						
Bass spaces						

2 Treble clef notes

★☆☆

Write the letter name under each note. The first is done.

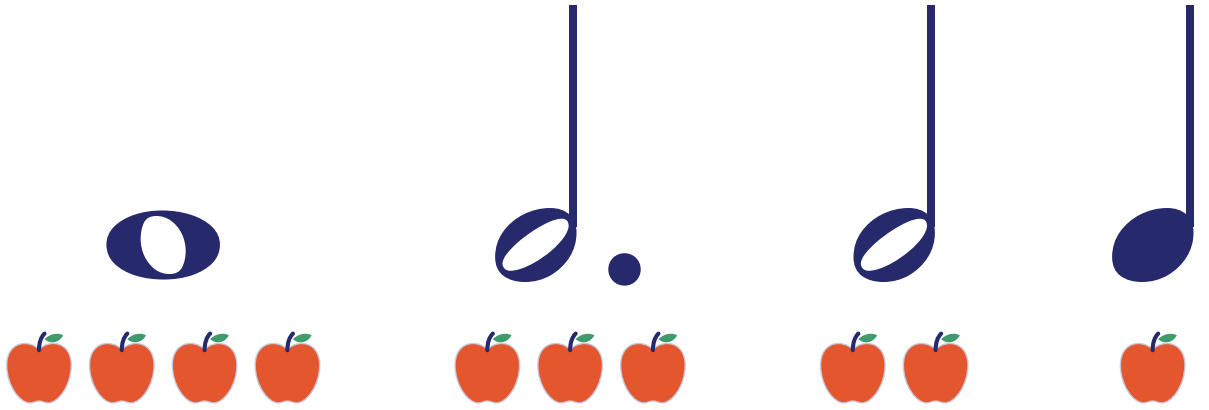


G



How long is a note?

SCAN TO LISTEN



Think of one beat as **one apple**. A **crotchet** is one apple. A **minim** is two, a **dotted minim** three and a **semibreve** four.

Now come the notes shorter than one beat: pieces of the apple.

AT THE PIANO

Play C as a semibreve, a dotted minim, a minim and a crotchet, counting the apples out loud: 1 2 3 4.

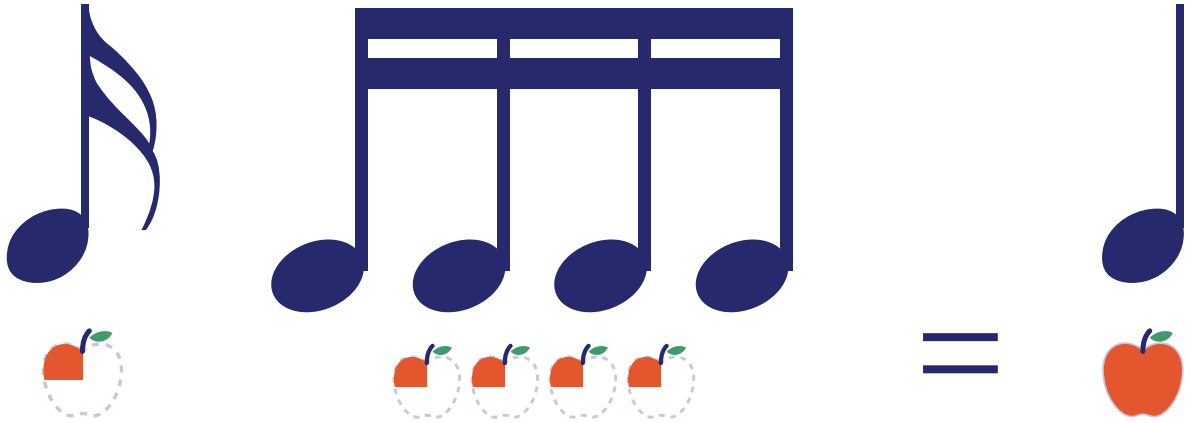


Cut the apple in half. A **quaver** is **half a beat**. One quaver on its own has a **tail**. Two or more join their tails into a **beam**.

Two quavers make one beat. We count them: **1 and 2 and**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C in crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Then in quavers, counting 1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and.

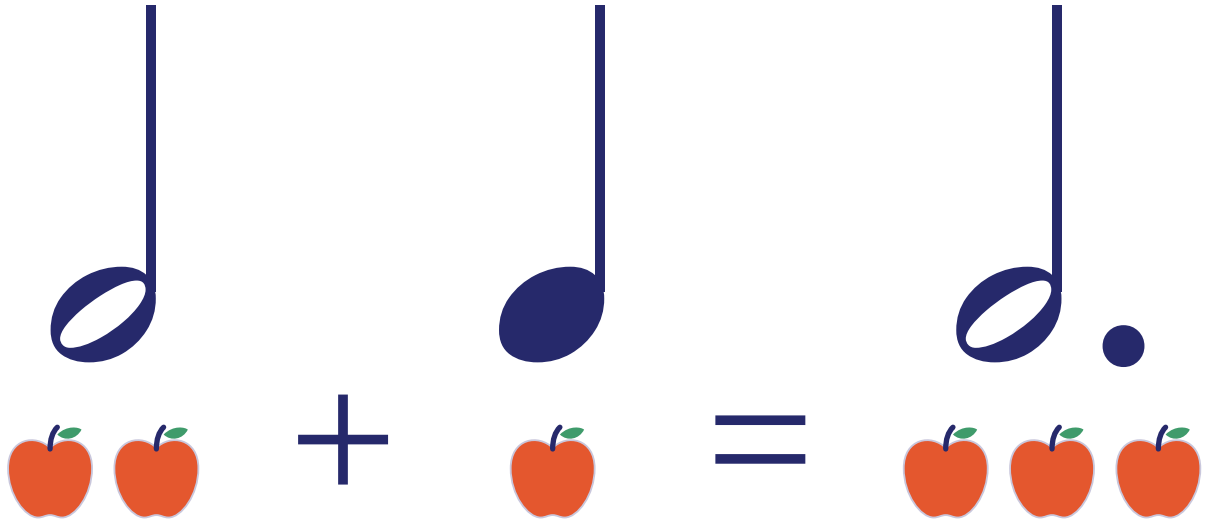


Cut each half again. A **semiquaver** is a **quarter of a beat**. It has **two tails**, or two beams when they are joined.

Four semiquavers make one beat. Say **wa-ter-me-lon** on each beat.

AT THE PIANO

Clap four beats. Then tap four semiquavers on every beat, saying wa-ter-me-lon.

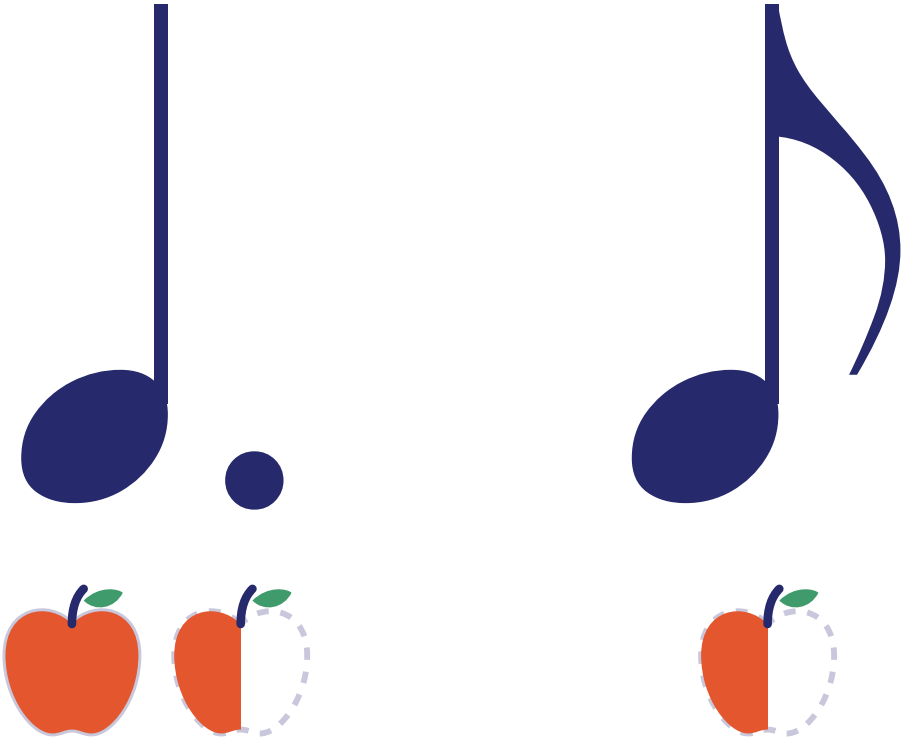


A **dot after a note** makes it longer: it adds **half** of the note again.

A minim is 2 beats. Half of 2 is 1. So a dotted minim is 2 + 1 = **3 beats**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C as a minim, counting 1 2. Then as a dotted minim, counting 1 2 3.



The same dot works on a crotchet: 1 + ½. A **dotted crotchet** is **one apple and a half**.

A quaver usually follows it to finish the second beat. Long, then short: **1 – 2 and**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C long, then D short, counting 1, 2 AND. The D comes on the “and”.



2 + 1 = 3 beats

A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes of the **same** pitch. Play the first one and **hold** through the second.

A minim tied to a crotchet lasts three beats.

AT THE PIANO

Play C and hold it for 1 2 3. You have played two notes with one press.



1 beat



2 beats



4 beats

A **rest** is a beat of **silence**. You count it just like a note, but you do not play.

The crotchet rest lasts 1 beat. The minim rest sits on a line for 2. The semibreve rest hangs under a line for 4.

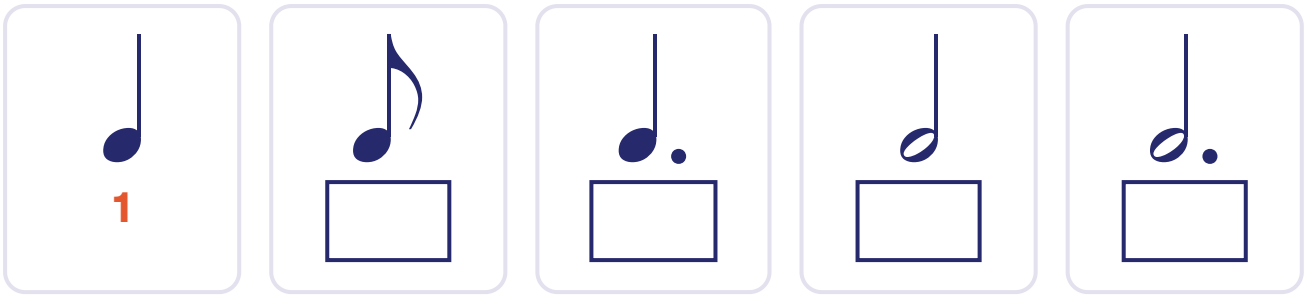
AT THE PIANO

Play C, C, then lift your hand for one beat, then C: 1, 2, (rest), 4. Keep counting through the silence.

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

Write the beats. A quaver is ½. The first is done.



2 Add them up

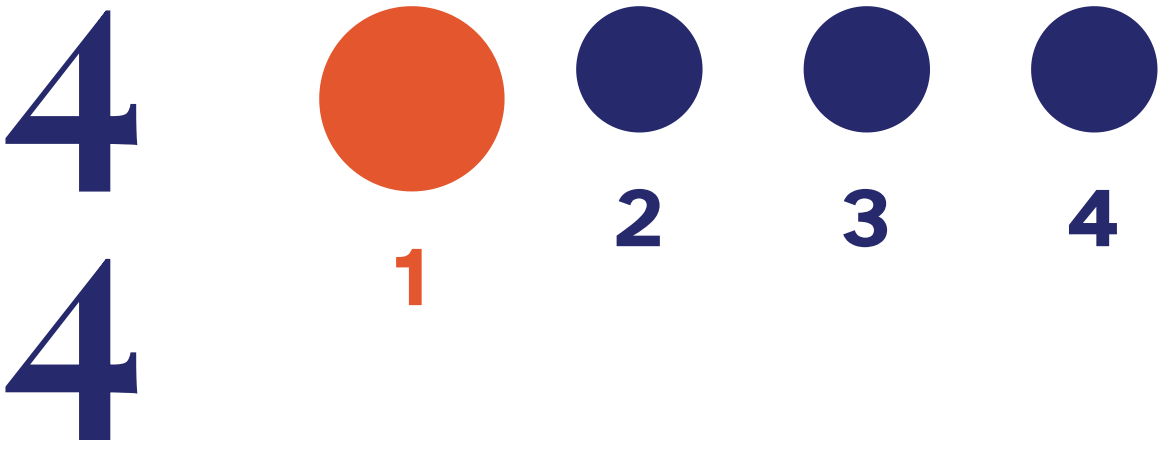
★★☆

Write the total number of beats. The first is done.

NOTES	BEATS
	1
	
	
 (tied)	
	

Time signatures

SCAN TO LISTEN



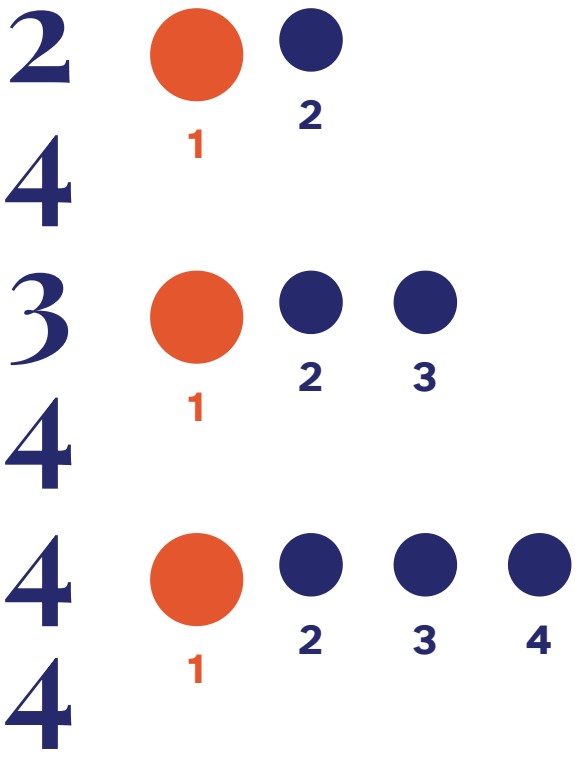
The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**.

The **top number** says how many beats are in every bar.

The bottom 4 says each beat is a crotchet.

AT THE PIANO

Clap four beats in a bar, the first one stronger: ONE two three four.



Two in a bar marches: left, right. **Three** in a bar swings round, like a waltz. **Four** in a bar walks.

Beat 1 is always the strongest.

AT THE PIANO

Clap each one: ONE two · ONE two three · ONE two three four. Which does your piece use?

1
Andante
at a walk

2
Moderato
not slow, not fast

3
Allegro
quick and lively

A word above the first bar tells you **how fast** the beat goes. The words are Italian.

Andante is a walking speed. **Moderato** is in the middle. **Allegro** is quick and lively.

AT THE PIANO

Clap four beats Andante, then Moderato, then Allegro. Find the speed word at the top of your piece.

1 How many beats in a bar?

★☆☆

Write the top number that fits. The first is done.

ONE BAR	BEATS
	3
	
	
	
	

2 Two, three or four?

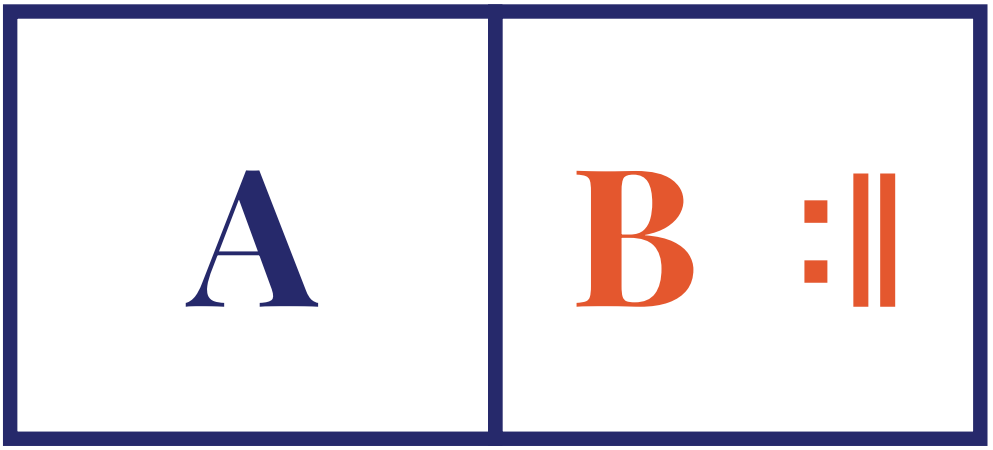
★★☆

Clap each one with a strong beat 1. Write 2, 3 or 4.

IT FEELS LIKE…	BEATS IN A BAR
LEFT right, LEFT right	
ONE two three, ONE two three	
ONE two three four	

Repeats

SCAN TO LISTEN

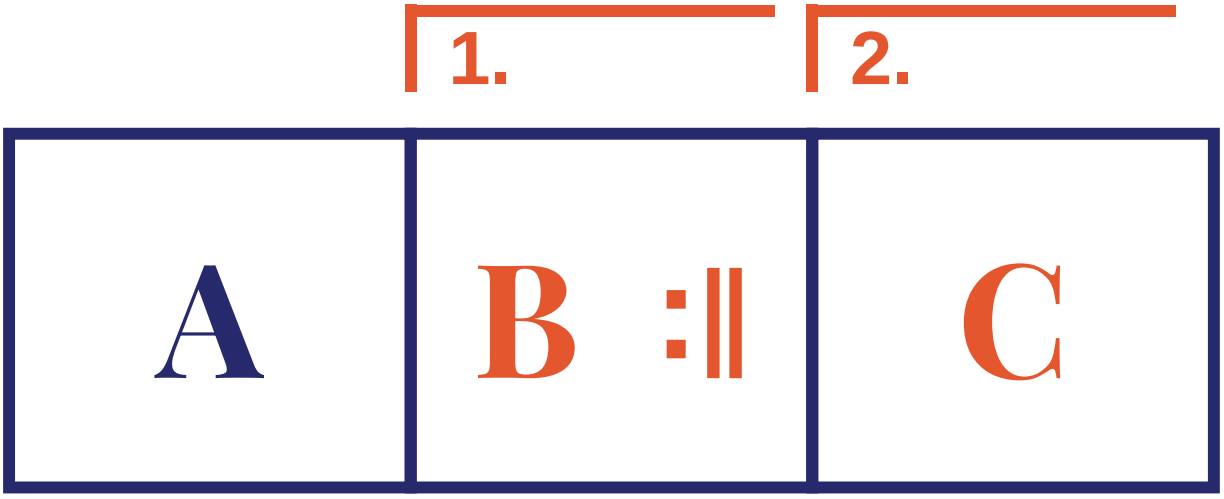


Two dots beside a double bar line make a **repeat sign**.
It means: **go back and play it again**.

So this music is played A B, then A B once more.

AT THE PIANO

Find a repeat sign in your book. Play up to it, then go back to the start and play it again.



Sometimes the ending changes. The bar marked **1** is played the first time only.

The second time, **skip it** and jump to the bar marked **2**: A B, then A C.

AT THE PIANO

Say the order out loud for this picture: A, B, back, A, C. Then look for a first-time bar in your music.

1 Write the order

★☆☆

Each letter is one bar. At a repeat sign, go back to the start once. Write the letters in the order you play them. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
A B :‖	**A B A B**
A :‖ B	
A B C :‖	
A B :‖ C	

2 First and second time

★★☆

The bar marked 1 is played the first time only; the second time you skip it and play the bar marked 2. Write the order. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
A [1. B :‖ [2. C	**A B A C**
A B [1. C :‖ [2. D	
A [1. B :‖ [2. C D	

Room 8 ◆ 1 of 2

Touch: smooth and short

SCAN TO LISTEN



The same notes can be played in different ways. **Legato** means smooth and joined. **Staccato**, a dot above or below the note head, means short. (A dot *after* a note makes it longer.)

An **accent** (>) means that note is stronger.

AT THE PIANO

Play C D E F G smoothly, each finger passing the sound to the next. Then play it staccato, like hot keys.



A curved line over **different** notes is a **slur**. Play them smoothly, in one breath, and lift gently at the end.

A tie joins the same note; a slur joins different ones.
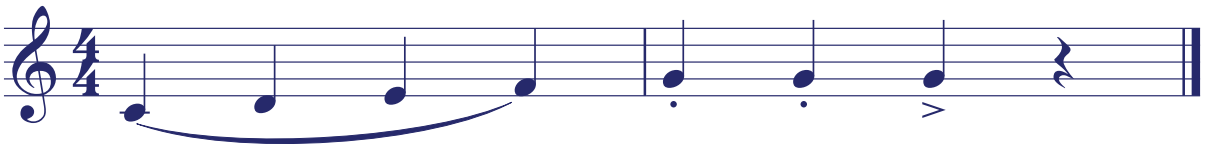
AT THE PIANO

Play C D E F as one slur: sink into the C, float off the F.

1 Which notes are short?

★★☆

Look at the music and complete the sentences. The first is done.



Bar 1 is played [joined] (joined or short).

In bar 2, [ ] notes have a staccato dot.

The last G has an [ ] .

2 Slur or tie?

★☆☆

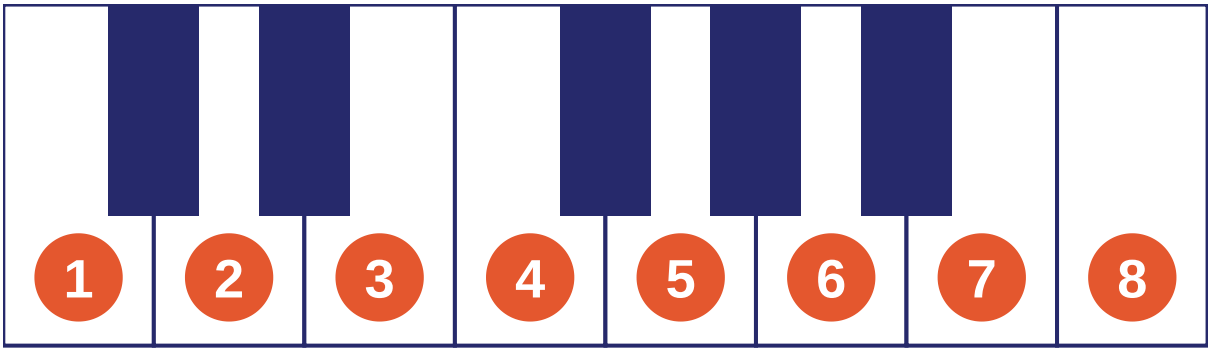
Circle slur or tie. The first is done.

a curve over C D E	**(slur)** · **tie**
a curve joining G and G	**slur** · **tie**
a curve over E F	**slur** · **tie**
a curve joining two Bs	**slur** · **tie**

Room 9 ◆ 1 of 4

Major scales

SCAN TO LISTEN

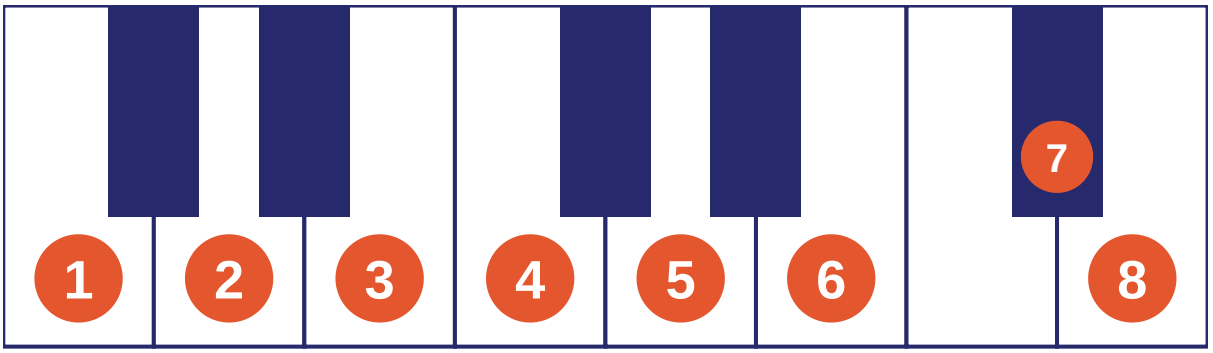


A **scale** is a ladder of eight notes. Play the white keys from C to the next C and you have **C major**.

Notes **3–4** and **7–8** are close together, with no black key between. Every other pair has a black key between.

AT THE PIANO

Play C major going up with one finger, saying the numbers 1 to 8. Listen for the two close steps. (Fingering comes in step 3.)

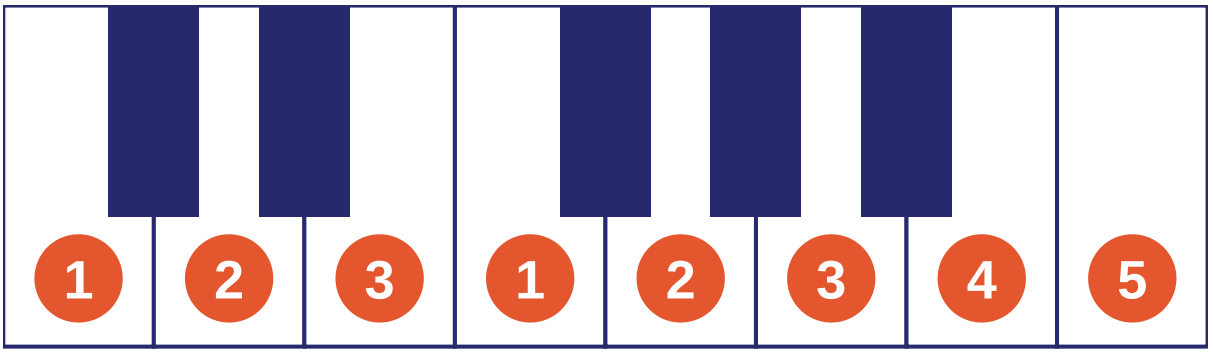


Start the same ladder on G and one note has to change: the 7th note becomes **F sharp**, so that 7–8 stay close. A **sharp** (♯) is the very next key to the right, here a black one.

That is **G major**: one sharp, F♯.

AT THE PIANO

Play G A B C D E, then the black key F♯, then G. Now try it with a white F: hear how it sounds wrong.



Eight notes, five fingers. Going up, the right hand plays **1 2 3**, then the **thumb tucks under** and plays **1 2 3 4 5**.

From one C to the next is one **octave**. Coming down, play 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1.

AT THE PIANO

Right hand, C major, one octave up and down, slowly. Say the finger numbers. Your teacher will show you the left hand.

0	1 ♯
C major **A minor**	**G major** **E minor**

Music in G major would need a sharp on every F. So one sharp is printed once, right after the clef. That is the **key signature**.

No sharps: C major or A minor. One sharp: G major or E minor.

AT THE PIANO

Look at the start of your piece. How many sharps are after the clef? Say which two keys it could be.

1 Write the scale

★☆☆

Write the eight notes going up. The first is done.

SCALE	NOTES
C major	**C D E F G A B C**
G major	

2 Where are the close steps?

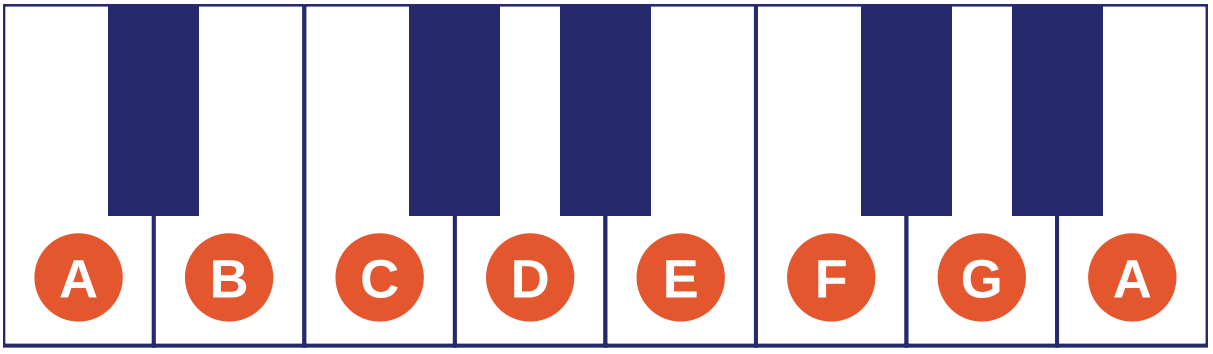
★★☆

In a major scale two pairs of notes are close together, with no key between. Write their numbers.

Notes ☐ – ☐ and notes ☐ – ☐

Minor scales

SCAN TO LISTEN

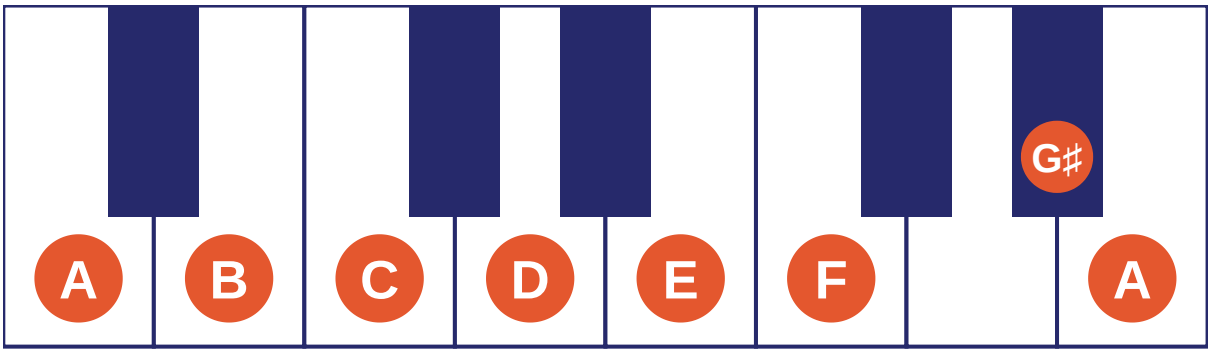


Play the white keys from A to A and you have **A minor**. It uses the same notes as C major, but A is home, and it sounds darker.

This plain form is the **natural minor**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C major up and down, then A natural minor. Same white notes, a different mood.

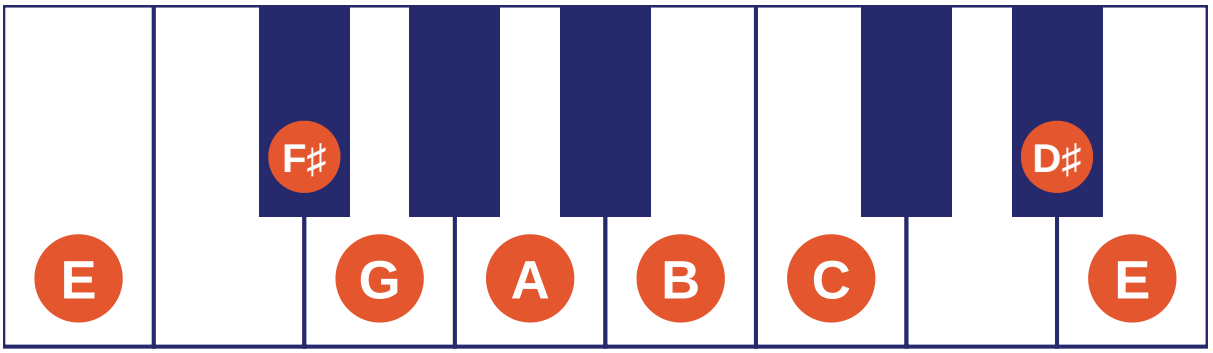


Raise the 7th note one key, G to **G sharp**, and the scale pulls strongly back home.

This is the **harmonic minor**: A B C D E F G♯ A.

AT THE PIANO

Play A harmonic minor slowly. Stop on G♯ and feel how much it wants to go up to A.



E minor uses the same notes as G major, so it keeps **F sharp**. E is home.

For the harmonic minor, raise its 7th note too: D becomes **D sharp**.

AT THE PIANO

Play E natural minor (with F♯), then E harmonic minor (F♯ and D♯).

1 Write the scale

★☆☆

Write the eight notes going up. The first is done.

SCALE	NOTES
A natural minor	**A B C D E F G A**
A harmonic minor	
E natural minor	
E harmonic minor	

2 Which note is raised?

★★☆

In the harmonic minor the 7th note goes up one key. Write it. The first is done.

SCALE	THE 7TH NOTE BECOMES
A harmonic minor	**G sharp**
E harmonic minor	

3 Same notes as...

★☆☆

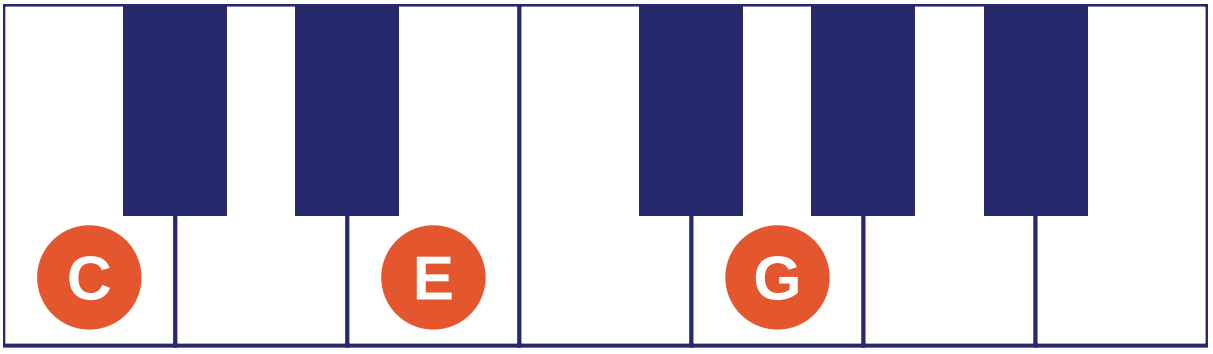
Each minor scale shares its notes with a major scale. Write it.

MINOR	MAJOR
A minor	**C major**
E minor	

Room 11 ◆ 1 of 2

Chords and triads

SCAN TO LISTEN

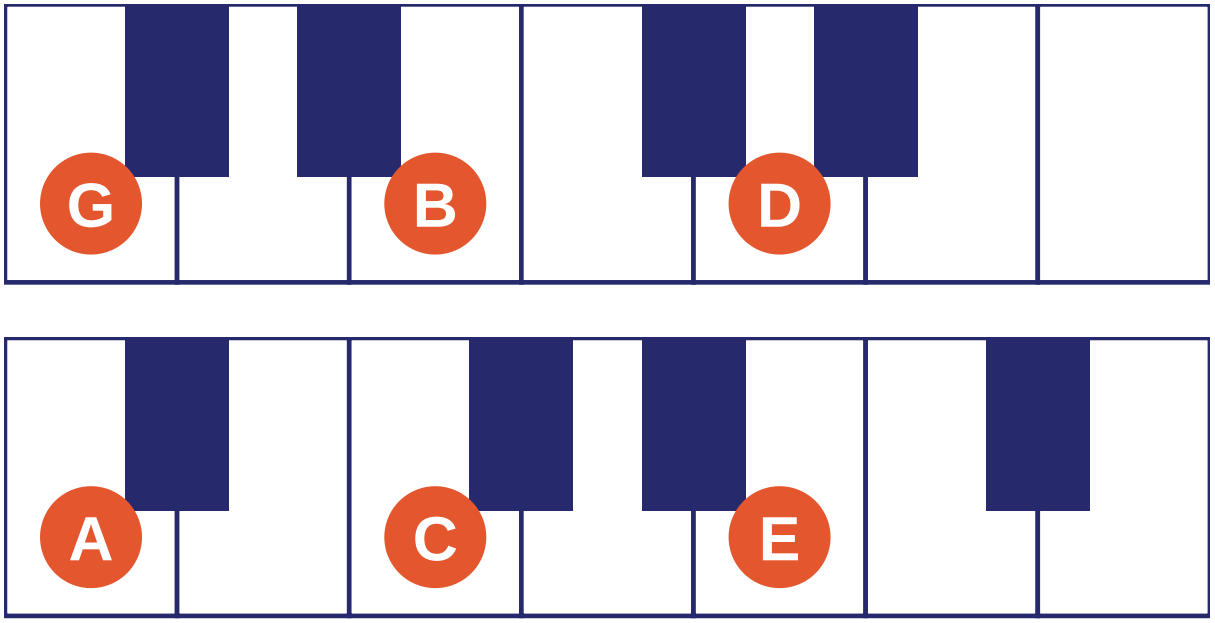


A **chord** is three or more notes played together. The simplest chord is a **triad**: three notes.

To build one: **play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one**. C, E, G.

AT THE PIANO

Right hand fingers 1, 3 and 5 on C, E and G. Play them one at a time, then all together.



The same shape works on other white keys too. On G it gives **G B D**. On A it gives **A C E**.

The bottom note names the triad. C and G sound bright: **major**. A sounds darker: **minor**.

AT THE PIANO

Keep your hand in the triad shape and move it: C E G, then G B D, then A C E.

1 Build the triad

★☆☆

Play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one. Write the three notes. The first is done.

ON	THE TRIAD
C	**C E G**
G	
A	
E	

2 Major or minor?

★★☆

Play each triad and listen: bright or dark? Circle one. The first is done.

TRIAD	
C E G	(major) · minor
A C E	major · minor
G B D	major · minor
E G B	major · minor

Room 12 ◆ 1 of 1

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1

Clap the beat

2

Echo the rhythm

3

Sing the tune

4

Higher or lower?

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Four listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

AT THE PIANO

Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

1 Clap the beat ★☆☆

A grown-up plays in two or in three, slow or quick. Clap the beat, and keep clapping when the music stops.

2 Echo the rhythm ★☆☆

They clap a short pattern. Clap it back exactly.

3 Sing the notes ★☆☆

They play five notes slowly, one at a time. Sing each one after it.

4 Higher or lower? ★☆☆

They play two notes. Say whether the second is higher or lower. Tick a circle for each day you play these games.